

Stone Age detective

Archaeologists do more than dig up artifacts. To find out about life in the past, they use some of the same techniques as police detectives. For example, using chemicals to date artifacts tells us how old a material is or when it last saw sunlight. Archaeologists also make replicas (models) of Stone Age tools to find out how our ancestors might have used them.



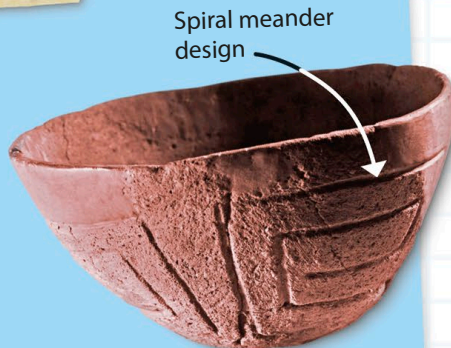
The very dry landscape and geology in the Olduvai Gorge helped to preserve the Stone Age tools and fossils.

Olduvai Gorge

In the Olduvai Gorge in Tanzania, Africa, archaeologists have found traces of early humans that are more than 2 million years old. These include some of the earliest evidence of humans using tools to chop up animals, discovered from cut marks on animal bones.

Neolithic bowl

At the end of the Stone Age, pottery became more common to hold crops and food. By analyzing remains left in the pottery, such as dried food, archaeologists can work out what people ate. Similar pottery styles also help us to link cultures and communities.



Spiral meander design



Making stone tools required intelligence and skill. By studying how tools were made, archaeologists can determine the abilities of our early ancestors.